

Use Sync for Stress-free Data Backup

A disk crash or a corrupted file can have disastrous consequences. A safe bet is to backup one's data. The author narrates his personal experience with data backup issues and gives a tutorial in the use of Sync, which he recommends for home users.



Most of you are probably active users of various services like Gmail, Flickr, Google Photos, Apple iPhotos and Instagram, or at least, must be aware of them. Many of you might also be users of digital storage options like Dropbox. While these services do give you the flexibility of easy availability of data anywhere in the world (assuming you have the bandwidth to access the data), you need to maintain a local copy (on your laptop or desktop) of all your data, much as vendors may try to convince you that all the data is safe with them. In case the local copy gets corrupted, one can always depend on cloud storage.

While data stored in the cloud is mostly safe, there have been cases where the cloud service provider has accidentally deleted user data. Additionally, data can be lost in case there is a data breach and the cloud provider's service gets compromised or passwords get stolen. Considering these possibilities, some of us are not comfortable in relying entirely on cloud services.

Personally, I make limited use of cloud-based storage services and mostly depend on keeping data in local storage. Having made the decision of 'going local' I need to take steps to ensure that the data is properly backed up, so that I will have a copy of the data, in case the primary storage fails. For important things like photographs, email and financial documents, I

maintain two backup copies of data. In other words, I have the actual data in local storage, as well as a backup of the data on two different portable HDDs (hard disk drives). Due to this approach, I need to use a well-defined and simple backup process.

A survey of personal backup solutions

Over the years, I have used many methods to maintain backup copies of data. The first method obviously was to maintain a copy of each file. Then I started storing compressed versions of the data and using a timestamp for each backup. Just as enterprises have had to address the Big Data explosion, I too have not been immune to the problem of large volumes of data. Due to data volumes and the frequency of changes, the timestamp method of maintaining backups is not practical. Additionally, each zip archive ends up with one copy of the file and when a particular copy is needed, it is difficult to figure out the most relevant copy.

I also tried using version-control software like SVN. The problem with version control is that it's sub-optimal for binary data. In other words, version control is best suited for text files, where versions are stored using the 'difference' method. In the case of binary files, most such solutions simply copy the binary file into the repository, as